

EGDI in South Asian Countries

The E-Government Development Index (EGDI) is a globally recognized composite indicator developed by the United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs to measure how effectively governments use digital technologies to deliver public services, enhance governance, and promote citizen participation.

1. What is EGDI?

EGDI is a composite index (0–1 scale) that evaluates a country's digital governance readiness and performance. It is published every two years in the UN E-Government Survey.

It reflects three key dimensions:

Availability and quality of online services

ICT infrastructure

Human capacity to use digital services

It is therefore not just about websites—it measures the overall ecosystem of digital governance.

2. Pillars (Components) of EGDI

EGDI is calculated as the average of three sub-indices:

(a) Online Service Index (OSI)

Measures the scope, quality, and accessibility of government online services

Includes portals, e-services, digital transactions, and open data

Example:

Bangladesh has strong OSI performance due to expanding e-services and digital platforms.

(b) Telecommunication Infrastructure Index (TII)

Measures ICT infrastructure availability, such as:

Internet users

Mobile subscriptions

Broadband access

Weak infrastructure = limited digital governance effectiveness

(c) Human Capital Index (HCI)

Measures education and skills of citizens:

Literacy rate

School enrollment

Digital literacy

Without human capacity, digital services remain underused

Mathematically:

$$\text{EGDI} = (\text{OSI} + \text{TII} + \text{HCI}) / 3$$

3. EGDI Classification

Countries are grouped into four levels:

Very High (0.75–1.00)

High (0.50–0.75)

Middle (0.25–0.50)

Low (0.00–0.25)

4. Comparative Situation in South Asia (2024)

South Asia shows moderate but uneven development in e-governance.

Regional Ranking Snapshot (2024)

India – 62nd

Maldives – 94th

Sri Lanka – 98th

Bangladesh – 100th

Bhutan – 103rd

Nepal – 119th

Pakistan – 136th

Afghanistan – 188th

5. Country-wise Comparative Analysis

BD Bangladesh

Rank: ~100 (2024)

EGDI: ~0.657

Strength: Strong online service delivery (OSI)

Weakness: Limited full end-to-end digital services

Bangladesh now performs above global average and leads among LDCs.

IN India

Highest performer in South Asia

Strong OSI and ICT infrastructure

Large-scale digital platforms (e.g., digital identity, e-services)

However, regional inequality and digital divide remain challenges

IN Sri Lanka

Traditionally strong in human capital (education, literacy)

Moderate OSI and infrastructure

Balanced performance but slowed by economic constraints

In Nepal

Rank: 119

Improving gradually

Weakness:

Poor online service delivery compared to regional peers

In Pakistan

Rank: 136

Lower performance in all three pillars

Major constraints:

Infrastructure gaps

Institutional inefficiencies

Afghanistan

Rank: very low (188)

Minimal digital governance capacity

6. Key Regional Patterns

1. Digital Divide

Wide gap between India/Bangladesh and Afghanistan/Pakistan

2. Infrastructure Constraint

TII is the weakest pillar across South Asia

3. Service vs Capacity Gap

Some countries (e.g., Bangladesh) perform well in OSI but lag in full automation

4. Human Capital Advantage

Sri Lanka leads in HCI

Other countries lag in digital literacy

7. Critical Evaluation

Strengths of EGDI

Comprehensive (covers services, infrastructure, skills)

Globally comparable

Policy-relevant

Limitations

Does not fully measure service quality or user satisfaction

Ignores regional inequality within countries

Focuses on readiness rather than outcomes

8. Conclusion

The EGDI provides a holistic framework for assessing digital governance, combining technological, institutional, and human dimensions.

In South Asia:

India and Bangladesh are emerging leaders

Sri Lanka remains strong in human capital

Nepal and Pakistan lag behind

Afghanistan faces structural barriers

Overall, the region is progressing, but infrastructure gaps, digital literacy, and institutional capacity remain major challenges.